

TABLE 8.8 : PERCENTAGE OF CHILDREN 6-14 ATTENDING SCHOOL BY SEX FOR DISTRICTS, 1971

District	Percentage of children 6-14 in school		
	Total	Male	Female
Sri - Lanka	70.9	72.6	69.2
Colombo	76.6	77.5	75.7
Kalutara	77.4	78.7	76.1
Kandy	70.6	73.0	68.1
Matale	66.7	68.4	65.0
Nuwaraeliya	62.1	67.1	57.0
Galle	76.4	77.5	75.2
Matara	76.1	77.2	74.9
Hambantota	68.9	69.6	68.2
Jaffna	79.5	80.3	78.6
Mannar	68.3	72.3	64.4
Vavuniya	67.8	69.2	66.3
Batticaloa	52.3	54.5	50.1
Amparai	58.9	62.3	55.4
Trincomalee	58.3	61.1	55.3
Kurunegala	72.7	73.6	71.9
Puttalam	65.9	67.7	64.0
Anuradhapura	65.0	66.5	63.4
Polonnaruwa	68.0	68.3	67.8
Badulla	64.3	68.3	60.2
Moneragala	56.5	59.1	54.0
Ratnapura	64.9	66.6	63.2
Kegalle	74.4	75.5	73.2

8.8 School attendance by single years of age and sex

Table 8.7 shows the percentage of children of each age and sex attending school in the urban and rural sectors separately. For the country as a whole the percentage of children attending school increases sharply from a low of 15 percent at the age of 5 years (minimum age of school attendance is now 6 years) to 60 percent at 6 years of age and then gradually to a peak of 79 percent at age 9. It declines gradually thereafter. The pattern is very much the same for the males and females except that at each age the school attendance rate is slightly higher for the males.

The same pattern also prevailed in the urban as well as the rural sector. However, school attendance rates in the urban sector are higher than the corresponding rates in the rural sector. The differences are small at the younger ages but increase with advancing age. This reflects both the greater availability and easier access to the schools, particularly the better schools, in the urban areas and the larger drop out rate in the rural areas.